



Combat Mindset — Proposed Way Forward

Joint NZALC and Human Performance Cell response to COMDT ACS

HARDER TO KILL

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Purpose

This paper responds to COMDT ACS direction of 16 July 2026 for NZALC and the Human Performance Cell to jointly develop a strategy to close the Combat Mindset doctrine and policy gap. It proposes an agreed problem statement, a terminology construct for decision, a joint programme of work, and governance arrangements.

1. The problem

Army has no defined doctrine or policy supporting Combat Mindset, despite the term being in active use and despite Army's drive toward an increased Warfighter Focus. The COMDT ACS guidance and the NZALC capability note independently reach the same diagnosis:

The challenge is not a lack of content. It is a lack of visibility, integration, doctrine and strategic ownership across the substantial capability that already exists within ACS, NZALC, the Human Performance Cell, NZDF Psychology and ILD.

The underlying operational problem remains as stated in the NZALC capability note:

Under operational pressure, trained individuals and teams do not always retain access to their full capability.

NZALC and HPC agree this diagnosis requires no further analysis before work begins. The gap is institutional, not intellectual.

2. Terminology — decision sought

The COMDT ACS guidance and the NZALC capability note differ on one structural point: which term sits at the top of the hierarchy. This is the single decision required before the framework can be drafted. Two options are offered.

Option 1 — Combat Mindset as the brand; Performance Under Pressure as the mechanism (recommended)

Combat Mindset is the Army-owned banner and orienting purpose, aligned to Warfighter Focus and carrying the brand promise: **Harder to Kill**. Performance Under Pressure is the doctrinal mechanism that sits beneath it — the trained individual and collective capacity the brand runs on.

Combat Mindset is why: acting decisively, persistently and ethically in combat — Harder to Kill. Performance Under Pressure is how: the trained capacity to prepare for, remain effective through, adapt within and recover from pressure.

- Preserves Combat Mindset as the recognisable, operationally credible Army brand, with Harder to Kill as its memorable, warfighter-focused promise.

- Keeps the underlying doctrine applicable Army-wide — command, crisis response, garrison leadership and high-risk technical activity, where pressure exists without an enemy.
- Guards against Combat Mindset being misread as aggression or motivation alone.
- Allows the doctrinal construct to nest cleanly beneath the brand in doctrine, learning design and assessment.

Option 2 — Combat Mindset as the umbrella capability

Combat Mindset is the overarching capability, integrating leadership, human performance, resilience, mental skills and performance cognition, with performance under pressure expressed as its intended effect.

- Maximises simplicity: one term, one capability, one framework.
- Risks excluding the majority of Army activity that is demanding but not combat, and re-importing the definitional confusion identified in the capability note.

Both options deliver the end state described in the COMDT ACS guidance. NZALC and HPC jointly recommend Option 1, and will implement whichever option COMDT ACS selects.

3. What already exists

A full joint map is the first task of the programme of work. In outline, the known holdings are:

- NZALC — the Performance Under Pressure package (Performance = Potential – Interference, Red Head–Blue Head, Prepare–Perform–Recover, the mental-skills toolkit), embedded across Lead Self, Lead Teams, Lead Leaders and Lead Systems, with experiential delivery, psychometrics, feedback and Leadership Development Plans.
- Human Performance Cell — the Performance Cognition programme (COGCON), including arousal regulation, attention control, cognitive flexibility, decision-making under cognitive load and dual-task performance development, with an associated evidence and measurement base.
- NZDF Psychology and ILD — supporting content, professional expertise and delivery capacity to be confirmed during mapping.

Initial review indicates the NZALC mental-skills toolkit and the COGCON constructs map closely — for example arousal regulation to tactical breathing and grounding, attention control to noticing and chunking, cognitive flexibility to reframing, and decision-making under load to game planning. The framework will integrate these into a single evidence-based strand rather than two parallel vocabularies. This mapping will be validated jointly during Phase 1.

4. Proposed programme of work

1. Phase 0 — Governance and definition (by end July 2026).

Confirm sponsorship and sub-sponsorship arrangements, endorse the problem statement, and select the terminology option at paragraph 2. Draft the Army-endorsed definition of Combat Mindset for staffing.

2. Phase 1 — Joint mapping and gap analysis (August 2026).

Map existing content, courses, instructor capability, delivery activity and assurance mechanisms across ACS, NZALC, HPC, NZDF Psychology and ILD. Scope is Army, with NZDF-level interfaces identified rather than absorbed. Identify gaps, duplication and integration opportunities.

3. Phase 2 — Framework development (September 2026).

Draft the Army Combat Mindset Framework: definition, desired operational effect, integrated strands (leadership, mental skills, performance cognition, resilience and recovery, values and professional identity, physical performance), and the developmental pathway aligned Lead Self through Lead Systems.

4. Phase 3 — Stakeholder forum (September 2026).

Convene ACS, HPC, NZDF Psychology, ILD and selected force employers to refine the framework and implementation approach.

5. Phase 4 — Pilot (October 2026).

Apply the framework to selected existing NZALC or ACS activity before any new content is designed, to prove the framework in delivery and generate evidence for refinement.

6. Phase 5 — Report back (November 2026).

Present Framework v1.0, the validated capability map, and an implementation and assurance plan for endorsement.

This sequence creates coherence across existing initiatives while avoiding duplication of effort and investment, consistent with the COMDT ACS guidance.

5. Governance

The following arrangements are proposed for confirmation at Phase 0:

- Army Sponsor — strategic owner of the Combat Mindset capability at Army level (to be confirmed through COMDT ACS).
- Sub-sponsor — COMDT ACS, driving and championing the capability on the sponsor's behalf.
- Capability development and delivery agency — ACS, leveraging NZALC leadership-development expertise, intellectual property and programmes.
- Technical authority — Human Performance Cell, ensuring the framework remains evidence-based and measurable, drawing on COGCON.

- Supporting stakeholders — NZDF Psychology, ILD, training establishments and force employers.
 - Assurance — designed into the framework from the outset, with a degree of independence from the principal delivery organisation.
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6. Recommendations

It is recommended that COMDT ACS:

1. **Endorse the agreed problem statement** at paragraph 1.
2. **Select the terminology construct** at paragraph 2 (Option 1 recommended).
3. **Confirm governance arrangements** at paragraph 5, including confirmation of the Army Sponsor.
4. **Approve the programme of work** at paragraph 4, including the joint mapping, stakeholder forum and pilot.
5. **Note** that NZALC and HPC will deliver this programme jointly, with the NZALC capability note and the COGCON evidence base as its foundation inputs.

Annex A — Common lexicon and division of functions

These tables give effect to the integration described at paragraphs 2 and 3. They are the joint NZALC–HPC working baseline and will be validated during Phase 1 mapping.

A1. Common lexicon — one construct, two layers

The framework adopts the cognitive-fitness dimensions as the science layer (HPC) and the NZALC mental-skills toolkit as the soldier-facing technique layer. One name per technique is used in delivery; programme-specific protocol names sit beneath it — for example, rhythm breathing is the COGCON conditioning protocol for tactical breathing.

Cognitive dimension (science layer)	Soldier-facing techniques (NZALC toolkit)	COGCON conditioning methods
Arousal regulation	Tactical breathing; grounding	Rhythm-breathing injects during high-intensity physical training; within-session heart-rate down-regulation
Attention	Noticing; chunking	Go/no-go attention drills; threat-identification dual-tasks; agility cones
Cognitive control	Motivational and instructional self-talk	Inhibition performance under load; adaptive difficulty progression
Working memory	Chunking; individual and team game planning	Audio-brief retention and recall during concurrent tasks
Self-knowledge	Structured reflection; psychometrics; Red Head–Blue Head	Performance monitoring; coach scoring and feedback; Team Awareness drills

A2. Division of functions — by function, not organisation

Function	Lead	What it looks like
Educate	NZALC	Concepts and toolkit taught and applied through leadership development, Lead Self to Lead Systems
Condition	HPC	COGCON dual-task repetitions embedded in physical training, with adaptive difficulty
Expose	Joint	Scenario and experiential pressure training, co-designed
Measure	HPC	Heart-rate regulation, attention and inhibition thresholds, progression level reached
Review and recover	NZALC	Structured reflection, self and peer feedback, Leadership Development Plans

Assure	Joint	Cognitive-readiness metrics (HPC) alongside observed leadership behaviour (NZALC)
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A3. Shared frames

- Prepare–Perform–Recover is the common delivery rhythm: COGCON operates principally in Prepare and Perform; NZALC closes the loop in Recover.
- Lead Self to Lead Systems is the common progression: conditioning is densest in initial and individual training; leadership application deepens up the continuum.
- The Phase 4 pilot embeds the COGCON adaptive dual-task protocol within an existing NZALC serial — NZALC teaching and reviewing, HPC conditioning and measuring — to prove the integration in delivery.